

# A Guide to This Project's Deliverables

*Advancing a Collaborative Youth Behavioral Health Data Strategy / MHSU Alliance, Health District of Northern Larimer County*

This project was built to give Estes Park, Poudre, and Thompson School Districts a shared, verified way of understanding student behavioral health, something none of the three districts currently has on its own. Right now, each district collects its own data using its own surveys, on its own schedule, and none of them track some of the most important indicators, like persistent sadness, suicidal ideation, or experiences of racism, at the school level at all. That makes it hard to know which students are struggling, which schools need more support, and whether the work already happening across the county is actually reaching the students who need it most.

The work is organized into a series of documents, each building on the one before it. This guide explains what each one contains and how to use it, so the package makes sense on its own, even without someone there to walk you through it.

## Why This Work Matters

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The 2023 Healthy Kids Colorado Survey, the most comprehensive source of youth behavioral health data available for this county, found that one in four Larimer County high school students experienced persistent sadness or hopelessness severe enough to disrupt their normal activities, and that nearly one in eight seriously considered suicide. County-wide averages like these can hide as much as they reveal: some groups of students, including transgender students and Hispanic and Latino students, report these experiences at rates far higher than the county average shows. Without a shared, disaggregated data system across all three districts, there's currently no reliable way to see these patterns, track whether they're improving, or coordinate a response.

## What's in This Package

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**1. Bibliography and Summary of Findings.** A review of the research on youth behavioral health data systems and screening tools, including what similar counties and school systems have found works well. It covers what a coordinated data system should look like, why so many students go without support under current systems, and which screening tools are the strongest candidates for a county like ours. This is the background reading that grounds everything that follows in evidence rather than guesswork.

**2. Environmental Scan.** A detailed look at what each district currently measures about student behavioral health, and where the gaps are. It documents which surveys each district uses, what those surveys actually cover, and where the same topic is measured in incompatible ways across districts. It uses verified data from the 2023 Healthy Kids Colorado Survey to show what's working well in Larimer County and where students, particularly those in specific groups, are being underserved by the current systems.

**3. Survey Crosswalk Workbook.** A side-by-side comparison of every survey currently used across the three districts, showing which questions measure the same thing, which only look similar, and where each district's data can or cannot be directly compared to the others. It also identifies specific gaps and inconsistencies worth knowing about, cases where two districts appear to ask the same question but are actually measuring something different. This is the technical foundation the rest of the project builds on.

**4. Shared Metric Recommendations.** Nine specific survey questions recommended for all

three districts to use in common, so the county can finally see one consistent picture of student behavioral health instead of three separate, incompatible ones. Each recommendation includes the exact question wording and answer choices, ready to use directly, along with an explanation of why that specific wording was chosen and what it would cost each district to adopt. Adopting all nine requires no new spending, since every item is already free through the existing statewide survey.

## How to Use This Package

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These documents are meant to be read in whatever order is most useful to you, not necessarily start to finish.

- Start with the **Environmental Scan** if you want the clearest picture of why this work matters and what it found locally, including how your district's current data compares to the other two.
- Go to the **Survey Crosswalk Workbook** if you want to see exactly what your district currently measures, in detail, and how it lines up against the other districts and the statewide survey.
- Go to the **Shared Metric Recommendations** if you're ready to act. It has the specific, ready-to-use survey language your district could adopt directly, along with a short explanation of what each item would take to implement.
- The **Bibliography** is there for anyone who wants the research background behind the approach, useful if you're presenting this internally and want the evidence base to point to.

## A Few Terms You'll See

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**HKCS** (Healthy Kids Colorado Survey): the statewide survey that provides the verified baseline numbers used throughout this package. It's administered every two years and is free for districts to use.

**CO-MTSS** (Colorado Multi-Tiered System of Supports): the state framework these recommendations are designed to align with, meant to help schools identify and support students at every level, from universal screening to individual intervention.

**Disaggregated data** means results broken out by group, race, gender identity, income, and so on, rather than reported only as one county-wide average. It's a recurring theme in this package because averages can look fine while hiding real problems for specific groups of students.

**Questions and next steps.** This package was developed through the MHSU Alliance's Summer 2026 internship at the Health District of Northern Larimer County. None of these recommendations are a requirement, they're a resource districts can adopt on their own timeline, with the reasoning and the data already worked out. Reach out to the MHSU Alliance with any questions, we're glad to walk through any part of this in more detail.